

Hitler's Role in the Soviet Victory

Forces fought on every continent except Antarctica in WWII, but no area was as important as Europe's Eastern Front. The battle against the USSR was the main factor in the Nazis' defeat. However, the first months of the war on the Eastern Front appeared to foreshadow a dominant Nazi victory as "every German soldier killed" resulted in the death of "twenty Soviet soldiers."¹ Although the USSR initially faced a crushing defeat, it prevailed over the Nazis almost four years after the German invasion. Many factors contributed to the Soviet victory, such as the Soviet people, production, and brilliant military leadership. However, the most important factor in the Soviet victory was the man who ordered its invasion. Hitler's mistakes during the war ultimately led to a Soviet victory as he did not listen to his military advisors, declared war on the U.S., waged a war of annihilation, failed to wage total war, and severely underestimated Soviet determination.

During the Nazi advance and eventual retreat to Germany, Hitler's orders significantly undermined Nazi Germany's war effort. He ignored advice from his military advisors and prevented the Wehrmacht from retreating. Unlike Stalin, Hitler grew more untrusting of his military advisors during the war. After a string of successes that his advisors did not support, Hitler believed he was the only one capable of leading the Germans to victory. His mistakes began when he invaded the Soviet Union to "rid the world 'once and for all' of the Soviet menace."² After ordering the invasion, he split Germany's military into thirds and created Army Group North, Central, and South. While this was initially successful, the divided Wehrmacht and Luftwaffe could not achieve all their goals. After the capture of Kyiv and Smolensk, the Germans struggled to bring Leningrad to its knees. Hitler played a role in the failures at Leningrad. He stopped the offensive and instead began a siege of the city.³ By halting the offensive, Hitler gave the Soviets more time to complete defensive fortifications and increase production behind the Ural Mountains, ensuring the Germans would fight into the brutal winter. Although a continued offensive would have led to bloody urban warfare, the Germans likely would have taken the city and dealt a symbolic blow to the Soviets. Additionally, the Germans could not capture Moscow after splitting their forces. With just one-third of their military might, they came within twelve miles of Moscow's center.⁴ If either Army Group North or South had joined Army Group Center in the battle, the Red Army would have struggled even more to hold the Soviet capital. After failing to capture Moscow, the Eastern Front became a war of attrition that benefitted the Soviets. Had Moscow fallen to the Germans, the Soviet's economic revival would not have played a role in the war. Later in the war, Hitler did not allow his punch-drunk troops to withdraw. In Stalingrad, General Friedrich Paulus believed that he could have "easily" broken out of the Soviet encirclement.⁵ However, Hitler refused and ordered him to "stand fast at

¹ Overy, *Russia's War*, pg. 117.

² Ibid, 61.

³ Ibid, 105.

⁴ Ibid, 142.

⁵ Ibid, 179

all costs.”⁶ His orders led to an unnecessary loss of life, prevented the Germans from regrouping at better defensive positions, and wasted German manpower that could have made a difference in the Battle of Kursk.⁷

Hitler’s failures increased the international aid that the Soviets received and significantly improved their ability to compete with the Nazis. Had the Germans taken Moscow or Leningrad, "the effect on the Soviet public and on world opinion" would have been "devastating."⁸ Critical Lend-Lease aid was already delayed due to doubts about the USSR's ability to keep fighting and would have certainly been delayed further or canceled if Leningrad or Moscow fell. Another strategic error was Hitler's declaration of war on the USA. The declaration of war increased aid to Hitler's Western enemy in Great Britain and gave the USSR a "powerful-comrade in arms."⁹ American aid proved to be vital to the Soviet victory. General Zhukov admitted in 1963 that if the USSR “had to deal with Germany one-to-one,” they “would not have been able to cope” since they had lost so much production capacity.¹⁰ As Zhukov stated, transporting nearly fifty thousand industrial factories East was not enough to match German production; they needed American aid.¹¹ The USSR received roughly fifteen million boots, one million miles of telephone wire, and three hundred fifty thousand trucks throughout the war.¹² This aid increased Soviet military mobility and allowed them to focus specifically on war production.

Adolf Hitler gave the USSR a valuable source of propaganda and weakened the Nazi war machine due to his policy of *Vernichtungskrieg*, or war of annihilation. From the beginning of Operation Barbarossa, Hitler intended to wipe the Soviets and the communist system from the face of the Earth. Nazis looted and destroyed Soviet cities while "raping and torturing the women, young and old," during their eastward advance.¹³ Once the Soviets had evidence, the USSR used reports and images to produce brutal and hate-filled propaganda. This propaganda united the Soviet people and encouraged them to fight or face the same fate. *Vernichtungskrieg* also hindered the German war machine's strength and ability to produce goods. Upon arrival in western Soviet territory, the Nazis "were hailed by much of the population as liberators."¹⁴ Therefore, the Nazis had the opportunity to use the local population's apparent hatred for the Soviet Union to either feed their troops or even let them join their ranks. Nonetheless, roughly "one million Soviet soldiers ended up fighting against their country," but thousands more would have joined if the Nazis did not treat the Soviets so horrifically.¹⁵

⁶ Ibid.

⁷ Ibid, 120.

⁸ Ibid, 95.

⁹ Ibid, 120.

¹⁰ Ibid, 195.

¹¹ Ibid, 83.

¹² Ibid, 196.

¹³ Ibid, 261.

¹⁴ Ibid, 83.

¹⁵ Ibid, 128.

Although the Nazis committed to a "war to the death" on the Eastern Front, they did not commit to total war at home.¹⁶ German women and children did not play a large role in factories on the home front for most of the war. In contrast, the Soviets, having suffered massive losses in the initial months of the German invasion, "survived only by mobilizing two-thirds of its women to run the factories and farms."¹⁷ Unlike the Soviet Union, Germany missed the additional production capacity that working women and children bring to the economy. As a result, "the rump Soviet economy... began to produce larger quantities of tanks, aircraft, and artillery than the Germans, who had four times as much steel."¹⁸ While the Allies' bombing campaign diminished German production, Hitler's failed total war policy limited it even further. Nazi Germany primarily relied on slave labor to staff their factories, but additional help from German citizens would have allowed Germany to maximize its resources and increase production.

Throughout the war, Hitler and the Nazis underestimated the Soviets' will to keep fighting. Hitler initially stated, "you only have to kick in the door, and the whole rotten structure will come down."¹⁹ His initial assumption proved incorrect even though the Germans killed roughly nine million Soviets during the war.²⁰ The dark history of the USSR played a role in increasing Soviet toughness and ability to withstand adversity as they had already overcome famines, Dekulakization, and the Great Purge. The men and women that the USSR relied on during the war were the "survivors of an era of turmoil that had cost well over fifteen million lives in little more than two decades."²¹ German soldiers struggled to understand the Soviets' will to fight, and a Luftwaffe pilot even said the Soviets were "not men, but some kind of cast-iron creatures."²² Eventually, the Soviet people's determination "brought them to the gates of Berlin" and overwhelmed the Nazis. The Soviet people's sacrifice played a significant role in Germany's defeat and destroyed eighty percent of Germany's fighting power. However, if Hitler had accounted for their unwillingness to give up or "almost suicidal courage," the Germans would have been more prepared, and a Soviet defeat would have been likely.²³

Germany's dominance led to rapid territorial gains on both the Western and Eastern Front and the swift defeat of France in the early 1940s. Before Operation Barbarossa, Nazi Germany was in complete control of continental Europe, and WWII became Germany's war to lose. Although the USSR recovered its economic strength, reformed its military, produced brilliant leaders, and fought with almost unwavering morale, Hitler's mistakes had the most prominent role in the Nazis' defeat.

¹⁶ Ibid, 82.

¹⁷ Ibid, 212.

¹⁸ Ibid, 169.

¹⁹ Relics World Editors. "Quote by Adolf Hitler." *Relics World Quotes*, 13 Nov. 2019, <https://www.relicsworld.com/adolf-hitler/you-only-have-to-kick-in-the-door-and-the-whole-rotten-author-adolf-hitler>.

²⁰ Overy, *Russia's War*, pg. 318

²¹ Merridale, *Ivan's War*, pg. 6

²² Ibid, 176.

²³ Ibid, 213.